

YASIR IQBAL

**KAJOL** opens up about how nervous she was to play Sujata in Salaam Venky

CINEMA

# ON PERILOUS PARENTHOOD

Based on a true story, *Salaam Venky* stars Kajol as a mother who nurtures a son with a rare Duchenne muscular dystrophy

**Q. *Helicopter Eela*, *Tribhanga* and now *Salaam Venky*–all these films show different hues of motherhood. Would it be fair to say it's a role that's never easy, no matter how familiar it is?**

But women make it easy because we are taught to multitask from the time we are children. We are told that you will never have just one role in life and you will have to satisfy all of them, all the time. We put unexpectedly strong expectations on ourselves, not realising we are human beings, too.

**Q. Seen together, the films show that no mother is the same, yet there's a lot that binds them...**

Everybody goes into parenting thinking of their own childhood, and not wanting to repeat their parent's mistakes. Yet, everyone comes out doing exactly that. That's the crux of being a parent–realising there's no manual. All you can hope is that your children figure s**t out before you do.

**Q. You got to meet Venky's mother, Sujata. How difficult was it to get into her shoes?**

If I tried to go there, I would not have been able to do the film. No parent wants to see their child sick in any way. She says she didn't do anything great but what was necessary. So, if it meant carrying him on her back to cinemas because he was a Bachchan fan, or climbing a temple, she did it. I was nervous to play her. I really hope and pray I live up to it.

**Q. With *Tribhanga* and *Salaam Venky*, you have been directed by two actresses who have now turned directors. Are you tempted to sit in the director's chair?**

That cap ain't coming to my head. I think it takes a certain attitude to be a director and I don't have it. Revathy and Renuka [Shahane] are amazing directors. On *Salaam Venky* [sets], I never saw Revathy once raise her voice. She has this way of putting people at ease. I was desperate to please her.

**Q. Will *Salaam Venky* start a conversation around euthanasia?**

Revathy will put you in a spot. You are definitely going to think about it and worry about it. There's a beautiful line in the film, 'If we have the right to live with dignity, we should also have the right to die with dignity'. That strikes a chord with everybody.

**Q. You are finally taking the plunge and doing your first series, an adaptation of the US TV show *The Good Wife*. What took you so long?**

This just had the right combination of writer, director and platform, and it came at the right time. I have been picky about what has been coming my way since I have kids. But I also want them to understand a working woman is a very normal thing. ■

***with Suhani Singh***


